from New York Harbor in early 1784, just months after the signing of the Treaty of Paris that ended the American Revolution. It was not until May 1800, during the "Quasi War" with France, that the USS *Essex* became the first US Navy vessel to reach Asia, porting at Batavia (now Jakarta) in the Dutch East Indies. Having crossed the Atlantic and rounded the Cape of Good Hope into the Indian Ocean, taking the same route as the *Empress of China* previously, the *Essex* was to escort back to the United States a convoy of merchant ships and protect them from French privateers, which were equally potential prizes, should they be encountered.[8] For the young nation, then, "Asia" was initially reached via the Atlantic and Indian Oceans, and the "Indo" part of what we today call the Indo-Pacific was not considered inseparable from the rest but was actually the main theater of operations in these earliest years.

Yet America was destined to focus its Asian energies through and in the Pacific Ocean. Perhaps ironically, given the name of the ocean, it took another armed conflict, the War of 1812, to pull American power into the Pacific. In January 1813, the same USS *Essex* became the first US naval ship to round Cape Horn and transit into the Pacific, though without any specific orders to do so.[9] She was again in search of prizes, this time British. *Essex* nearly decimated British whaling ships in the rich hunting grounds in a few short months, forcing London to send the Royal Navy to hunt the American predator. Captain David Porter, commander of *Essex*, recklessly decided to confront the Royal Navy at Valparaiso, Chile, in March 1814, leading to the capture of his ship in one of the bloodiest battles in early US naval history.[10] Meanwhile, at the other end of the great ocean, near Batavia, the USS *Peacock* captured the British East India Company brig *Nautilus* in June 1815, after the war had ended but before word of the armistice reached across the globe. In the action, *Peacock* killed a number of the British crew, who were probably the last casualties of the war.[11]

Not until 1818 was a regular US Navy presence established in the eastern Pacific Ocean. In that year, the USS *Macedonian* was dispatched as the first ship of the United States Naval Forces on "Pacific Station,"